

THE BUSINESS MATURITY MODEL

Stage 6

Efficiency

You're spending more every quarter to grow, and the growth isn't keeping up. The machine got bigger and somehow less profitable.

20 TO 49 PEOPLE · \$10M TO \$30M REVENUE

You are here.

Every business climbs the same ten stages, set by how many people you've got and how much you make. You're at **Efficiency**. Here's what that means, across your whole business.

0	Foundation	Just you · Pre-revenue
1	Validation	Just you · Under \$100K
2	Traction	You + vendors · \$100K-\$500K
3	Structure	2-4 people · \$500K-\$1M
4	Focus	5-9 people · \$1M-\$3M
5	Expansion	10-19 people · \$3M-\$10M
6	Efficiency YOU ARE HERE	20-49 people · \$10M-\$30M
7	Systems	50-99 people · \$30M-\$75M
8	Division	100-249 people · \$75M-\$150M
9	Reinvention	250-500 people · \$150M+

Stage 6: Efficiency

WHO

20 to 49 people. You lead through managers now, two layers between you and the work.

THE CONSTRAINT

You keep spending to grow, and the money's going somewhere you can't see.

GRADUATE BY

Grow by getting better, not by getting bigger. Read the numbers and make the move they point to.

THE BIG PICTURE

You built a company. Two layers of managers, product that sells, a team that runs the day without you in every room. The early stages were about deciding who you serve and giving them more to buy, and you did it. Now a quieter problem shows up. You add headcount and ad spend and another tool every quarter, the top line climbs, and the profit doesn't move with it. The machine got bigger and somehow less efficient.

At this size you can't run the company from your head anymore. There are too many calls to make and too many of them are wrong by a little, and a little times forty people times twelve months is most of your profit. The business wins on paper and loses money in places nobody can point to.

Spending harder won't fix this stage. The businesses that break through stop assuming and start reading the numbers, one decision at a time. Which product to improve, which channel still pays, which rep needs which skill. You grow by getting better, not by getting bigger. Here's what that looks like across every part of your business.

The stage comes down to one shift: you stop running the business with no numbers to back you up and start running it from the numbers. The next pages run that shift across all three engines of your business.

Across your business.

Every business runs on three engines. Eight parts sit inside them. At Efficiency, one part is leaking in each engine right now. Those three are marked Start here. Get them right and the rest follows.

SALES & MARKETING

Marketing

START HERE

You've worked the warm audience, so every new dollar chases colder people who convert worse. Your cost per customer climbs and the easy growth is gone.
assembling ads from tested parts · The Sales Acceleration Formula borrowed authority on cold traffic · Influence

Sales

START HERE

Your closing rate slips as you grow, and it swings rep to rep. The wins live in a few people's heads and you can't copy them. *coach one skill the funnel picks · The Sales Acceleration Formula a documented, teachable method · The Sales Acceleration Formula*

OPERATIONS

Product & service

You try to improve two products at once and both stall. Everything gets a little better and nothing gets meaningfully better.

Customer service

Churn climbs as volume grows. You can't see which customers are leaving or why.

Technology

People come and go with access to your data and your accounts, and offboarding is a scramble.

FINANCE & ADMIN

Finance

START HERE

You're spending to grow and the money goes missing. The P&L looks fine while cash gets tight, because nobody's reading the business at the level where the leaks live. *gross profit per labor dollar · Simple Numbers the four forces of cash flow · Simple Numbers*

Hiring

The roles you need now sit outside your network, and you're filling them off whoever you happen to know.

Your people

You're trying to land senior talent and losing them on pay. They want full benefits and a retirement plan and you don't have one.

Start here.

The one part breaking each engine. Get these right and the rest of the stage gets easier. Each names the tell, what to do, and the book behind it.

Marketing SALES & MARKETING

Your cost to get a customer keeps climbing and nobody can say why.

THE CONSTRAINT

You've worked the warm audience, so every new dollar chases colder people who convert worse. Your cost per customer climbs and the easy growth is gone.

DO THIS

Stop reinventing the ad every time. Build a batch of proven hooks and a handful of core messages, then recombine them into dozens of variations a week. Test them against each other and let the winners spend. Borrow the authority of people your buyer trusts, because a colder audience defers to a known name faster than to you. You're assembling tested parts.

SOURCE assembling ads from tested parts · *The Sales Acceleration Formula*, Mark Roberge

SOURCE borrowed authority on cold traffic · *Influence*, Robert Cialdini

Sales SALES & MARKETING

One rep crushes the same lead another rep lets die, and you can't say what the good one does differently.

THE CONSTRAINT

Your closing rate slips as you grow, and it swings rep to rep. The wins live in a few people's heads and you can't copy them.

DO THIS

Write down how your best people sell, then teach it as one method everyone runs. Coach each rep on the single skill their numbers say is weakest. Pull the funnel by person, find where each one falls off, and drill that one stage with recorded calls until it moves. Standardize the play, then coach it by the numbers.

SOURCE coach one skill the funnel picks · *The Sales Acceleration Formula*, Mark Roberge

SOURCE a documented, teachable method · *The Sales Acceleration Formula*, Mark Roberge

Finance FINANCE & ADMIN

Profit's up on paper and the bank account doesn't agree.

THE CONSTRAINT

You're spending to grow and the money goes missing. The P&L looks fine while cash gets tight, because nobody's reading the business at the level where the leaks live.

BENCHMARK

Healthy here is 10 to 15% pretax profit, with two months of operating expenses sitting in cash. Above 15% is a great business, and competition and cost pressure bring it back toward 10 over time.

DO THIS

Build a financial-operations dashboard that reads the business by the slice. Break gross profit and cost-to-acquire-a-customer out by product, by department, and by lead source, so you can see which parts pay and which lose money, and make the call from the numbers. The number that runs this stage is gross profit per labor dollar, what each dollar of payroll earns back, because at twenty to forty-nine people payroll is still your biggest cost and your biggest lever. Start a balance sheet, and watch the ratio of what a customer is worth over their life against what you paid to land them, segment by segment.

SOURCE gross profit per labor dollar · *Simple Numbers*, Greg Crabtree

SOURCE the four forces of cash flow · *Simple Numbers*, Greg Crabtree

The rest of your business.

Not the three to start with, but they're in play at this stage. Here's the move on each, for when you're ready.

OPERATIONS

Product & service

You try to improve two products at once and both stall. Everything gets a little better and nothing gets meaningfully better.

DO THIS

Fix one thing at a time. Rank every possible improvement by the gain it buys, the cost to do it, and the risk it carries, then work the top one until it's done before you touch the next. Prune the features nobody values. Delete them, and add one back only if someone misses it.

Customer service

Churn climbs as volume grows. You can't see which customers are leaving or why.

DO THIS

Break your churn down by how long they stayed, by which product, and by which rep sold and serves them. That shows you which customers leave and why. Then fix the early experience that decides whether a new customer sticks, and test one change at a time so you know what worked.

Technology

People come and go with access to your data and your accounts, and offboarding is a scramble.

DO THIS

Tighten the front and back doors. Put proper security on the basics, run onboarding and offboarding off a checklist, and wire it so one click cuts a leaver's access the day they walk out.

FINANCE & ADMIN

Hiring

The roles you need now sit outside your network, and you're filling them off whoever you happen to know.

DO THIS

Hunt instead of waiting. Go find the people you need where they already work, run each finalist through a four-way fit check across the role and the team, and put yourself in the last interview with four or five reference calls behind it.

Your people

You're trying to land senior talent and losing them on pay. They want full benefits and a retirement plan and you don't have one.

DO THIS

Build the comp that senior people expect. Choose a benefits package against a clear set of criteria, and stand up retirement and the advanced pieces of pay, so the offer competes for the people you're now trying to hire.

Where you stand.

ON TRACK

- You build ads from tested parts instead of starting over each time
- Your reps run one written method and you coach one skill at a time
- You can read profit and cost-to-acquire by product and channel
- You know your gross profit per labor dollar
- You've got a balance sheet and two months of cash

STILL NEED WORK

- Your cost to get a customer keeps climbing and you can't say why
- Your best rep's playbook lives in their head
- You decide where to spend with no numbers to back it up
- Profit's up but the cash isn't there
- You improve everything a little and nothing a lot

Graduating to Stage 7. You'll know you're ready when the company grows because it got better. Your spend is efficient, your sales team runs one proven play, and you trust your numbers enough to decide by them. The next stage is about organizing all of it into systems before the volume overwhelms you.

What's this business worth to you when you're done?

Book a call and tell me the number you're building toward. I'll read where your spend is leaking and where your cash is going, and show you the one or two moves that turn this year's growth into profit you keep.

BUILT ON

This stage draws on **The Sales Acceleration Formula** (Mark Roberge), **Influence** (Robert Cialdini), and **Simple Numbers** (Greg Crabtree). The moves are ours. The thinking stands on theirs.